leadership. At the army banquet hosted by General Sir Mike Jackson, I was presented two medals of the Great War which my grandfather had earned but which had been lost at the time of Partition. It was a very touching gesture, and must have gladdened the spirit of the grand old man too. It was a matter of great pride for me. They have been mounted on a silver stand and find a pride of place in our home today.

Talking about our neighbourhood, our relations with China assume the greatest importance for peace, prosperity and stability of the region. We have a 'strategic and cooperative partnership' in place. There is enough space for sustained economic and social development and trade for both of us. The paths we have chosen are different but the aim is common – the well-being and prosperity of our people. Therefore, I believe that we may be competitors but we are not rivals. Our leaders have adopted a statesman-like approach and agreed to resolve our intractable boundary and other problems in a peaceful, mature and pragmatic manner.

The Government of India's response to the Chinese argument – that the boundary between the two countries had never been formally delimited – was: 'the Sino-Indian boundary, based on custom and tradition, follows natural features, and for the major part this customary and traditional boundary is also confined by treaty and agreement (between British India and Tibet, though the Chinese shied away from most of these treaties on some pretext or the other). This boundary has been fixed and well known for centuries. According to international usage and practice, a customary boundary which follows well known and unchanging natural features like the main watershed, stands defined and does not require further and formal definition.'[3]

A comprehensive review of the boundary dispute between India and China brings out that our northern border is sanctified by tradition and history over the centuries; that certain sectors of the boundary crystallized during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries due to the British empire's security concerns and that the